

THE COMPACT PLAYBOOK

Claude Cowork, end to end.

A feature inside the Claude desktop app where Claude works directly with your files, folders and apps.

13 sections

plain, practical

copy-paste prompts

SECTION 01

What Claude Cowork is

Claude Cowork is a feature inside the Claude Desktop app that lets Claude work directly with your files, folders, and apps. Where regular Chat tells you how to do something, Cowork actually does it — reading files on your computer, editing them, creating new ones, and delivering finished outputs.

Think of it as a working session, not a conversation. You describe an outcome, Claude plans the steps, you can step away while it works, and you come back to finished work.

Who Cowork is built for

Cowork brings Claude Code's agentic capabilities to non-developers. It's designed for anyone who spends real time on document-heavy, repetitive knowledge work:

- Researchers and analysts — synthesizing across sources, processing datasets
- Operations teams — file organization, batch processing, recurring reports
- Legal and compliance — reading dense contracts and pulling out what matters
- Finance teams — building spreadsheets, processing receipts, generating reports
- Marketing and content — turning rough notes into polished decks and docs
- Founders and consultants — automating the assembly work between thinking and shipping

Tip. No technical background required. If you can describe what you want, Cowork can usually do it. What it produces – Excel spreadsheets with working formulas, multiple tabs, conditional formatting – PowerPoint presentations from your notes or source files – Word documents and formatted reports – Organized, renamed, deduplicated folders of files – Synthesized research summaries pulling from multiple sources – Extracted, structured data from messy inputs

SECTION 02

Cowork vs Chat vs Claude Code

Anthropic has three modes of working with Claude. Picking the right one for the job saves a lot of friction.

	CHAT	COWORK	CLAUDE CODE
Best for	Quick questions, single-step tasks, brainstorming	Multi-step knowledge work with files and outputs	Codebases, engineering tasks, terminal workflows
Audience	Anyone	Non-developers and developers alike	Developers (and technical PMs/ops)
File access	No – you paste content in	Yes – reads and writes your local files	Yes – full project access

	CHAT	COWORK	CLAUDE CODE
Runs how long?	One turn at a time	Long-running multi-step tasks	Long-running, parallel agents
Where it lives	Web, mobile, desktop	Desktop app only (Mac, Windows)	Terminal, IDE, desktop, web
Mental model	Asking a smart person a question	Handing a project to an assistant	Pairing with a senior engineer

A simple rule

Need an answer or quick draft? → Chat

Need work done on your files? → Cowork

Need code shipped? → Claude Code

SECTION 03

Getting access

Requirements

- Claude Desktop app (macOS or Windows) — Cowork doesn't run on web or mobile
- Paid Claude plan Pro, Max, Team, or Enterprise. Not available on Free.
- Active internet connection during the session
- Computer awake and Claude Desktop open while tasks run

Install Claude Desktop

If you haven't already:

- Go to claude.com/download
- Download the installer for macOS or Windows
- Install and sign in with your Claude account
- Make sure you're on the latest version (Cowork requires it)

Find Cowork inside Claude Desktop

- Open Claude Desktop
- Look for the mode selector with Chat and Cowork tabs
- Click the Cowork tab — the interface switches to Tasks mode
- You're now in Cowork. Type your task into the box.

Warning. Cowork is a research preview. It's powerful but rough in places. Anthropic explicitly says: don't use it for regulated workloads. Cowork activity isn't captured in Audit Logs, Compliance API, or Data Exports. For anything sensitive, stick with regular Chat. Mobile companion (Pro & Max only) Pro and Max users can also send tasks to Cowork from their phone. Claude runs the task on your desktop using your local files, and the results show up in the same conversation. You don't need to be sitting in front of the computer — but it does need to be on, awake, and signed in.

SECTION 04

The 5-step flow

Every Cowork task follows the same pattern. Once you've done it once, the rest is variation.

01 Switch to Cowork

Open Claude Desktop, click the Cowork tab. You're in Tasks mode now.

02 Describe what you want

Tell Claude the outcome you need. Don't worry about specifying every step — Cowork plans the steps itself. Focus on what "done" looks like.

Weak: “Help me with my receipts”

Strong: “Look at the receipts in my ~/Downloads/Receipts folder. Build an expense report as an Excel file with columns for date, vendor, amount, and category. Total at the bottom. Sort by date.”

03 Review Claude’s plan

Before doing anything, Claude shows you the plan it’s going to follow. Read it. If something is off, say so before it runs:

‘Sort by category instead of date.’ ‘Skip the personal receipts — only the ones in the Work subfolder.’ ‘Use USD even if some receipts are in other currencies.’ ‘If the plan looks right, let it run.’

04 Watch it work (or walk away)

Cowork shows progress as it goes — what file it’s reading, what step it’s on, what sub-tasks it’s coordinating. You can:

Warning. If Cowork tries to delete files, it always asks for your explicit permission. You’ll see a permission prompt — click Allow before it can delete anything. Step 5 Review the output Cowork delivers the finished work to your file system (or wherever you said). Open it, verify it, and tell Claude what to refine if needed. The conversation stays open — you can ask for changes the same way you would in chat.

SECTION 05

Global and folder instructions

Out of the box, Cowork doesn't know your role, your preferences, or how your team operates. Instructions fix that — and they persist across sessions.

Global instructions

Apply to every Cowork session you run. Use these for stable things about you: your role, your tone preferences, your default formats.

HOW TO SET THEM

- Open Claude Desktop
- Go to Settings → Cowork
- Click Edit next to Global instructions
- Type your standing instructions
- Click Save

EXAMPLE GLOBAL INSTRUCTIONS

SAMPLE GLOBAL INSTRUCTIONS

I work as a marketing manager at a B2B SaaS company. Default to professional but conversational tone (not corporate) Use US English, US date format (MM/DD/YYYY) When generating spreadsheets, use \$ formatting for currency and put totals in bold When summarizing, lead with the bottom line — context after Always confirm before deleting or overwriting files If you need clarification, ask one question at a time, not a list

Folder instructions

Project-specific context tied to a folder. When you point Cowork at a folder with folder instructions, Claude uses them. Useful when different projects have different rules — your client work has different conventions than your personal projects.

Claude can also update folder instructions on its own during a session, so they evolve as you work.

What to put in instructions

- Your role and what you do day to day
- Tone, voice, and writing preferences
- Default output formats (spreadsheets, docs, slides)
- Naming conventions for files
- Things to always confirm before doing
- Things to never do without asking
- Common abbreviations or jargon specific to your work

SECTION 06

Projects – persistent workspaces

Projects in Cowork are workspaces that group related tasks together. They keep their own files, links, instructions, and memory across sessions. Best for recurring or long-running work.

When to use a project vs a standalone task

USE A STANDALONE TASK WHEN...	USE A PROJECT WHEN...
One-off job (organize Downloads, summarize one report)	Recurring work (weekly status, monthly expenses)
No need to remember anything for next time	You want Claude to remember context across sessions
Single-shot research	Ongoing research on a topic that grows over time
Just need an output, not a workflow	You'll come back to this repeatedly with related files

What lives in a project

- Files relevant to the work (uploaded or linked)
- Links to external sources
- Project-specific instructions overriding global settings
- Memory Claude remembers what happened across sessions in this project
- Task history specific to the project

Note. Memory is only retained within projects. Standalone Cowork tasks don't persist memory across sessions. If you find yourself re-explaining the same things, make it a project.

SECTION 07

Scheduled tasks

Scheduled tasks are work you set up once and Claude runs automatically — daily, weekly, or on demand. This is one of Cowork's most powerful features, especially for routine reports and recurring processing.

How to create one

Two ways:

- Type /schedule inside any Cowork task
- Click Scheduled in the left sidebar to view, create, and manage scheduled tasks

What makes a good scheduled task

- Repeats on a known cadence (daily, weekly, monthly)
- Has stable inputs (a folder, a connector, a known data source)
- Produces a predictable output (a report, a summary, a sorted folder)
- Doesn't require human judgment mid-task

Examples worth scheduling

- Every Monday morning: summarize emails from the past week from a specific sender or label
- Every Friday afternoon: build a weekly status report from a Notion page and Slack threads
- Daily at 9 AM: scan the team's shared Drive folder for new files and categorize them
- End of each month: build an expense report from the receipts folder
- Every Sunday: deduplicate and rename anything in the Downloads folder

Warning. Scheduled tasks only run while your computer is awake and the Claude Desktop app is open. If you close the app or your computer goes to sleep, the scheduled task won't fire.

SECTION 08

Plugins and connectors

Plugins

Plugins customize how Cowork works for your role, team, or company. Each plugin bundles together a set of skills (specific workflows), connectors (links to external tools), and sub-agents (specialized helpers) into a single package.

Think of a plugin as a pre-built role for Claude. A “recruiter” plugin might include skills for processing resumes, connectors to your ATS, and sub-agents that handle screening. A “finance ops” plugin might handle invoices, expense reports, and vendor records.

Plugins are installed inside Cowork. Browse what’s available, install the ones that fit your role, and they show up in your task flow.

Connectors

Connectors link Cowork to external tools and services. With them, Cowork can work across not just your local files but your full workflow.

COMMONLY USED CONNECTORS

- Google Drive read and write Drive files alongside local files
- Gmail process emails, draft replies, search inbox
- DocuSign work with contracts and signed documents
- FactSet pull financial data into reports
- Notion read and update Notion pages
- Slack pull threads, summarize channels
- Custom MCP servers connect to your team's internal tools

Connectors expand what Cowork can work with. Without them, you're limited to local files. With them, you can run end-to-end workflows that span email, cloud storage, and your team's tools.

Warning. Connectors get access to your data in those services. Only enable connectors from trusted sources. Review what data they can read and write before granting access.

SECTION 09

Safety – what to know before you let it run

Cowork can make real changes to your files. The safety design is built around three things: a sandboxed execution environment, explicit permissions for sensitive operations, and your active oversight.

The VM (sandbox)

Cowork runs inside a virtual machine on your computer. That means Claude's code execution is isolated from your main operating system — it can't accidentally break system files or run beyond the boundary. But it can still access the local files you've given it permission to work with, so review its planned actions before letting it touch sensitive files.

Deletion protection

Claude can't delete files without your explicit permission. Every delete operation triggers a permission prompt. Click Allow only after you've reviewed what's being deleted.

Network and connector permissions

- Cowork respects your existing network egress permissions
- Web search and MCP connectors can be turned off at the organization level (Team/Enterprise)
- Connectors only access what you grant them access to
- Review carefully before extending access to a new connector or website

What Cowork is NOT suitable for

Warning. Cowork is a research preview without enterprise compliance features. Cowork activity is NOT captured in Audit Logs, the Compliance API, or Data Exports. Do not use Cowork for regulated workloads (healthcare data, financial compliance, anything requiring auditability).

- HIPAA / PHI / patient health data
- PCI / payment card information
- Anything under SOX, GDPR audit, or similar compliance regimes
- Highly sensitive personal data of others
- Operations on production systems where mistakes are costly

What to review before running

- Which folder is Claude touching? Verify the path before you approve.
- What's the plan? Read it before letting it execute, especially for first-time tasks.
- Backups? For irreversible operations, make sure you have one.
- Connectors? Verify which ones have access for this task.

SECTION 10

Ten use cases with starter prompts

Copy, adapt, paste into Cowork. Pick the one closest to your real work first.

Organize a messy folder

01

FOR anyone with a chaotic Downloads or Desktop folder

STARTER PROMPT

Look at my ~/Downloads folder. Organize everything into subfolders by type (documents, images, installers, archives) and within each subfolder, by year. Rename anything with junk filenames (random strings, default "document.pdf") to something descriptive based on content. Don't delete anything — just sort and rename. Tell me what you did when finished.

Build an expense report from receipts

02

FOR anyone who travels for work or manages personal expenses

STARTER PROMPT

Look at the receipts (PDFs and images) in ~/Documents/Receipts/Nov2026. Extract date, vendor, amount, and likely category from each. Build an Excel file with columns for each, sorted by date, with a category-grouped total at the bottom. Flag any receipts you couldn't read clearly.

Synthesize research across multiple sources

03

FOR researchers, analysts, anyone doing literature reviews

STARTER PROMPT

Read all the PDFs in ~/Research/EVMarket and the notes in ~/Research/EVMarket/notes.md. Synthesize them into a single report covering: market size and growth, key players, regulatory environment, the 3–5 most important trends, and open questions the literature doesn't resolve. Cite which source said what. Save as EVMarket-Synthesis.docx in the same folder.

Turn meeting notes into action items

04

FOR managers, PMs, anyone running meetings

STARTER PROMPT

Read the transcript at ~/Meetings/2026-05-team-sync.txt. Extract: 1. Key decisions made 2. Specific action items with owners and rough deadlines 3. Open questions that didn't get resolved 4. Anything that needs to escalate Format as a clean follow-up email I can send to the team. Don't include filler conversation.

Build an Excel model from raw data

05

FOR analysts, finance teams, anyone working with messy data

STARTER PROMPT

Take the CSV at ~/Data/sales-raw.csv. Clean it (fix date formats, remove duplicates, standardize the region column). Build a proper Excel file with: a Data tab (cleaned data), a Summary tab (monthly totals by region with formulas, not pasted values), and a Charts tab with a line chart of revenue over time and a bar chart of revenue by region. Save as SalesAnalysis-May2026.xlsx.

Generate a presentation from notes

06

FOR anyone needing a slide deck from rough material

STARTER PROMPT

Read my notes at ~/Projects/Q2Review/notes.md. Build a 10-slide PowerPoint for the Q2 leadership review covering: highlights, key metrics (one slide per top-3 metric), what shipped, what slipped, lessons learned, and Q3 priorities. Restrained, executive-friendly design — minimal text per slide, big numbers where they appear. Save as Q2Review.pptx.

Review and summarize contracts

07

FOR legal teams, freelancers, anyone signing contracts

STARTER PROMPT

Read the contract at ~/Documents/Contracts/vendor-agreement.pdf. Produce a one-page summary covering: parties, term and renewal, payment terms, scope, IP ownership, termination, liability caps, and anything unusual or aggressive. Flag the 3 clauses I should pay closest attention to before signing. Save the summary in the same folder.

Weekly status report (scheduled)

08

FOR managers, founders, anyone reporting weekly to stakeholders

STARTER PROMPT

Set up a scheduled task to run every Friday at 4 PM: 1. Read the team's Notion workspace (use the Notion connector) 2. Pull recent Slack threads from #engineering and #product 3. Combine into a weekly status report covering: what shipped, what's in progress, blockers, and next week's focus 4. Save as ~/Reports/Status/YYYY-MM-DD.docx

Personal knowledge synthesis

09

FOR anyone who takes notes but rarely revisits them

STARTER PROMPT

Read all the markdown files in ~/Notes from the last 6 months. Find recurring themes, ideas I keep returning to, and questions I've raised but never resolved. Surface patterns I might have missed. Don't summarize – interpret. What does this collection of notes say about what I've been thinking about? Save the synthesis as Notes-Synthesis-May2026.md.

Batch document processing

10

FOR admin teams, anyone processing files in volume

STARTER PROMPT

Look at the PDFs in ~/Documents/JobApplications. For each one: 1. Rename to LastName-FirstName-Role.pdf based on content 2. Extract candidate name, role applied for, years of experience, and key skills 3. Build a master Excel tracker with all extracted data, sortable by date received Flag any duplicates or files you couldn't process. Save the tracker as ApplicationTracker-May2026.xlsx.

SECTION 11

Pro tips

Describe the outcome, not the steps

Cowork plans the steps itself. Telling it “first do this, then do that, then this” usually produces worse output than describing what “done” looks like and letting Claude figure out how to get there.

Always review the plan before letting it run

Cowork shows you its plan before executing. This is the single best moment to catch misunderstandings. Five seconds reviewing the plan saves twenty minutes fixing wrong output.

Start with read-only tasks before destructive ones

For your first few Cowork sessions, ask for summaries, analyses, or new file generation. Avoid renaming, sorting, or moving existing files until you've watched a few tasks play out and you trust the behavior.

Use folders, not individual files

Cowork is at its best when pointed at a folder of related material. Pointing it at one file is usually overkill — you could do that in Chat.

Build instructions over time

Every time Cowork makes a wrong assumption, add the correction to your global or folder instructions. Within a few weeks, your instructions become the user manual for working with you specifically — and quality goes up sharply.

Make projects for anything recurring

If you'll do a task more than twice, make it a project. The memory and persistent context make every future session faster. Memory doesn't persist across standalone tasks, only inside projects.

Schedule the tedious, boring stuff first

The highest-ROI use of Cowork is automating work you keep putting off because it's annoying. Receipt processing, file organization, weekly summaries — these compound into hours back every month.

Use connectors sparingly at first

Start with local files only. Once you've got a feel for how Cowork plans and executes, add one connector at a time. Each new connector adds capability but also surface area for things to go wrong.

Combine with Claude for Excel / PowerPoint

Cowork generates the file. Claude for Excel and Claude for PowerPoint refine it. Cowork is great at structure and content; the Excel and PowerPoint integrations are great at polish.

SECTION 12

Troubleshooting

PROBLEM	WHAT TO DO
Can't find the Cowork tab	Make sure you're on the desktop app, not the web version. Update Claude Desktop to the latest version. Confirm your plan is paid (Pro, Max, Team, or Enterprise).
'Setting up Claude's workspace' message at start Expected. Cowork is updating to the latest version. Just wait for it to finish.	

Claude stopped working on my task The Desktop app must stay open and your computer must stay awake for tasks to keep running. If either was interrupted, the session ends. Resume the task or restart it.

Hitting usage limits fast Cowork uses more compute than chat. Save it for the multi-step, file-heavy work that justifies the cost. Use regular Chat for simple questions.

Files aren't where expected Check file access permissions. Re-read where Claude said it saved the output (usually in the final message). Search by filename.

Claude is asking too many permission prompts Adjust permission settings for the connectors involved. Some can be set to "ask once per session" rather than every action.

Task is taking forever Cowork tasks can legitimately run for a long time on big jobs. But if it's stuck, stop the task and try again with a more scoped prompt (smaller folder, fewer files).

Output keeps missing the mark The issue is almost always the prompt. Be more specific about what "done" looks like, what format you want, and what to exclude.

Wrong direction completely Stop the task. Start a new one with a sharper prompt. Don't try to redirect mid-task on something big — the plan was wrong from the start.

SECTION 13

Your first 30 minutes

If you've never used Cowork, here's the fastest way to get from zero to confident.

Minute 0–5 Set up

- Claude Desktop installed (latest version) from claude.com/download
- Signed in with a paid plan
- A test folder to work with — pick something low-stakes like Downloads

Minute 5–10 Set global instructions

- Go to Settings → Cowork → Global instructions. Add 3–5 lines about yourself and your defaults. Keep it short — you can

always add more later.

Minute 10–20

Run your first task

- Switch to the Cowork tab. Try a read-only task — nothing destructive.
- Read the plan, read the output. This is how Cowork thinks. Get a feel for the rhythm.

Minute 20–25

Let it do real work

- Now let Cowork actually do something. Tell it to proceed with its suggested sort and rename. Watch the live progress. Verify the result.

Minute 25–30

Plan what to automate

- List 3 tasks from your real work that would be good Cowork candidates:
- Multi-step (would take you 30+ min manually)
- File-based (work with documents, spreadsheets, folders)
- Repeatable (you do them often enough to care about automation)
- Pick the highest-pain one. That's your next Cowork session.

EXAMPLE GLOBAL INSTRUCTIONS

I work as a [your role] focused on [your domain]. Default to a professional, conversational tone. Use US English and MM/DD/YYYY dates. Always confirm before deleting or overwriting files. Lead summaries with the bottom line, then context.

Tip. That’s it. You now have Cowork installed, global instructions set, and a real task completed. Everything else is practice. Quick Reference Card THE MENTAL MODEL BUILT-IN SAFETY Chat = ask a question, get an answer – Runs in a sandboxed VM Cowork = hand off a task, get finished work – Explicit permission required to delete Claude Code = pair with an engineer – Shows the plan before executing – Don’t use for regulated workloads THE 5-STEP FLOW – Switch to the Cowork tab HIGHEST-LEVERAGE SETUP STEPS – Describe the outcome – Set global instructions (5 min, every session benefits) – Review the plan before letting it run – Make a project for any recurring work (memory persists) – Watch or walk away – Schedule the boring repeating tasks (set once, runs – Review the output forever)

PROMPT FORMULA	WHEN NOT TO USE COWORK
Look at [files/folder]. [What you want done].	– Regulated data (HIPAA, PCI, SOX, GDPR)
[Output format and where to save].	– Production systems where errors are costly

PROMPT FORMULA	WHEN NOT TO USE COWORK
[Anything to exclude or watch for].	- Anything requiring compliance audit trails